Where to Begin When There's Time

Three first moves toward a plan for Mom's care, and what to leave for a professional.

Mom is managing on her own, so nothing presents itself as the first step. What you know is in pieces: a few notes, a folder of statements, a will signed years ago, something you once read about Medicaid.

Start here. Three moves, in this order, at whatever pace suits your family.

1 Put the pieces on one page

Take a sheet of paper and write five headings: Mom's care needs, what she and the family would prefer, her financial resources, what you've learned about Medicaid so far, and the legal documents you know exist. Under each, write what you have, however rough. For the financial heading, the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's list of what a person owns and owes is a fair guide: accounts, income, real estate, vehicles, insurance policies, investments, valuables and debts. Round numbers are fine. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Each piece has been kept somewhere different. Until they're on one page, nobody can see which ones are thin.

2 Mark what you know, what you're assuming and what nobody has looked at

Go back down the page with a pen. Put a K beside anything you've seen on paper or heard from Mom herself, an A beside anything you're assuming, and a question mark beside anything nobody has looked at. Where two people have told you different things, write down both, with who said each.

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The A's and the question marks are your open questions. A plan starts from those, and they don't show until they're marked.

3 Put a kind of professional beside each open question

For each open question, write who you think it belongs to: the family, your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, a licensed financial or insurance professional, a tax professional, or “not sure.” The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide lists the kinds of professionals a family may need help from, lawyers, financial advisors and accountants among them, and the Administration for Community Living counts wills, powers of attorney and exploring a person's qualifications for Medicaid among an elder law attorney's work. “Not sure” is a fine answer. [1] [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Which legal, financial, care and application steps may be appropriate is worked out with the right professionals. Knowing whose question is whose means a first meeting can start further along.

What to leave for a professional

- Whether anything on your page stands in the way of Medicaid for Mom. That depends on her state and her situation.
- Which legal or financial steps may be appropriate, if any.
- The order things would happen in, and when.
- Anything that would move, gift or retitle money or property, create or change a legal document, or buy or cancel insurance. Write the idea down as a question and ask first.

Before anything is moved or signed

Gathering and writing down change nothing, so they can go at your own pace. A change to Mom's accounts, her house or her policies is a different kind of step. Under the heading “Medicaid is complicated,” the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility for Medicaid. If someone suggests a change, write it on the page and take it to the professional it belongs to.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what your family should do about any of it, whether anything on the page is a problem, or when to act. It puts three first moves in order. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have one page with the pieces on it, your open questions marked, and a kind of professional beside each. The planning interview is the next step: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can keep with that page and bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The list of what a person owns and owes, the kinds of professionals a family may need and the caution about decisions that may affect Medicaid eligibility follow the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide. The description of an elder law attorney's work follows the Administration for Community Living. The five headings and the order of the three moves are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else’s money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Will I Need a Lawyer?